2009 result had left it despondent. The BJP, it seemed, was in terminal decline, the karyakartas were dispirited and the leadership was weak and fractious. The RSS, too, was facing the challenge of shrinking cadres, and a generational crisis was looming—a paradigm shift was called for. This is where Mohan Rao Bhagwat, the RSS *sarsanghchalak*(chief), decided to step in.

Bhagwat, a Maharashtrian Brahmin like many of his predecessors, was a third-generation RSS leader. With his walrus-like white moustache and wrestler-like physique (he was once the RSS's chief of physical training), he was not the kind of leader who would tolerate indiscipline. He became RSS chief in March 2009, just three months before the general elections, at the relatively young age of fifty-nine. The BJP was in disarray and Bhagwat was determined to correct it. 'He was angry and frustrated. He told us that either we change or it is all over for us. It is now or never!' says a BJP leader who attended an RSS–BJP meet.

One of his first tasks after taking over was to look for a new BJP president. Bhagwat wanted to bring in someone from outside Delhi for the post to reduce the friction. His first choice was Modi, but Modi wanted to focus on the 2012 Gujarat elections. He even considered Manohar Parrikar, but he, too, preferred to stay put in his home state of Goa. In the end, the mantle fell on Gadkari, the 'local' boy from Nagpur, the RSS's home turf. Gadkari had a warm relationship with Bhagwat—they sometimes dined together—and the explicit instruction was to unite the party. Voluble and expansive in more ways than one, Gadkari had tried and failed, like so many Maharashtra politicians before him, in taming north India. His business dealings came under the scanner as well—he is a businessman first, a politician much later, was a criticism within the party. The portly Gadkari is an interesting combination of bon vivant and *swayamsevak*. He'd invite you to lunch, declare he was on a diet and end up polishing off most of the meal! He also had a bagful of expletives, thrown at anyone who'd care to listen; he was the kind of individual who could abuse with a smile.

When the BJP lost badly in the UP elections in early 2012, Bhagwat knew time was running out for the party's revival. They needed someone